



Guinea is still struggling to cope with the legacy of the civil wars in neighbouring Sierra Leone and Liberia. The country hosted nearly one million refugees from these two countries for almost ten years, creating ethnic tensions and economic decline. Tens of thousands of people continue to be displaced inside Guinea as a result of fighting in the border regions in 2000-2001 – although the scope of internal displacement remains unclear. No comprehensive survey has been carried out since 2002, when the government put the total number of internally displaced at 82,000. Guinea's internal problems – not least frustration with the dictatorial President Lansana Conté who narrowly missed assassination in January 2005 – combined with a number of external threats have contributed to a growing sense of insecurity among Guineans. The conflict in neighbouring Côte d'Ivoire and the incomplete reintegration of Liberian ex-combatants – many of them trained in Guinea – continue to have a destabilising effect.

Acute protection concerns

In Guinea, IDPs to a large extent integrated with resident populations. As was the case with many Sierra Leonean and Liberian refugees displaced by the fighting in Guinea, it became apparent that Guinean IDPs also suffered human rights abuses during flight. According to an Amnesty International report published in 2001, Guinean civilians were killed, beaten, raped and abducted by armed political groups, including the RUF, in cross-border attacks from Sierra Leone. Women and children, estimated by the UN to make up 60 per cent of the IDP population, have been at particular risk. While large numbers of Guinean IDPs are believed to have returned to their homes by late 2002, there is scant data on the scope of the country's displacement crisis. The continuous movement of populations in the border areas and confusion about the categorisation of IDPs, refugees and Guineans returning from neighbouring countries has complicated efforts to identify the internally displaced as a group with particular needs and vulnerabilities.

Protection needs remain acute amid growing concern over ethnic tensions and tensions between refugees and host communities in the Forest Region – both worsened by a steadily declining economy. Border areas remain highly volatile, with an abundance of small arms and roaming fighters from Guinea as well as Liberia and Sierra Leone ready for recruitment by the highest bidder. This has also increased the risk of forced recruitment of children, sexual and gender-based violence particularly against refugee and displaced women and children, rising levels of crime and armed banditry, and increased levels of HIV/AIDS. Deteriorating security in Côte d'Ivoire with the resulting population movements would further impact on the situation in Guinea.

Deteriorating humanitarian situation

The humanitarian situation of IDPs in Guinea remains fragile almost six years after the height of the fighting. While some emergency assistance was provided at the time of the conflict, longer-term needs have generally been neglected. There has been no comprehensive assessment of the current needs of IDPs in Guinea, and no assistance with return and reintegration. The situation has been further blurred by the fact that most IDPs took refuge with overburdened host communities in urban districts.

Fighting in the border areas of Guinea's Forest Region caused major destruction in towns such as Guéckédou and Macenta, where 90 per cent of destroyed homes and public buildings still need to be rebuilt or repaired.

In Guéckédou, at least 25 to 30 per cent of returned IDPs are in need of food and shelter assistance. While some returnees have been able to resume agricultural activities, the majority lack the necessary seeds and tools. Host communities have borne the brunt of assisting the IDPs, putting an enormous strain on already limited school and health care facilities and resulting in food shortages and increased morbidity. Overall living conditions and coping mechanisms have steadily eroded as economic conditions continue to worsen.

In rural areas, access to arable land is still limited and the UN has reported that some 90 per cent of the population in general are suffering from hunger and malnutrition. One in three households is reported to be confronted with severe malnutrition, with children under five and pregnant and lactating women most affected. The nutritional situation has deteriorated considerably and is most worrying in the Forest Region. Lack of access to basic health and water services, poor hygiene as well as precarious living conditions have contributed to malnutrition as well as to the re-emergence of diseases such as polio, yellow fever and cholera. Most IDPs willing to return to their areas of origin, or to integrate into their areas of displacement, need assistance with protection, return and reintegration packages, including access to arable land, agricultural inputs, basic health, water and sanitation, and education services, according to the UN.

Negligible response

In Guinea IDPs have effectively been an invisible problem and the humanitarian response to them negligible at best, a situation exacerbated by a serious lack of resources. The government of ailing President Lansana Conté – re-elected for another seven year term in December 2003 – has been accused of crushing opposition and failing to implement reforms related to rule of law, respect for human rights and economic recovery. As a result, in 2004 most international donors – including the European Union, the World Bank and the International Monetary Fund – cut their bilateral cooperation and suspended their activities in the country. This in turn has been used as an excuse by the government for failing to maintain basic social infrastructures and services, and exacerbating the subsistence needs of vulnerable groups such as IDPs, Guinean returnees and host communities. The UN warned this could lead to a humanitarian crisis even in the absence of a war or a natural disaster. However, 2005 saw a measure of political progress – including the resumption of dialogue with the opposition and preparations for municipal elections – that resulted in the resumption of cooperation by key donors.

Many houses in Guéckédou remain in ruins several years after the fighting, Guinea, 2004
(Mpako Foaleng/IDMC)



Yet various factors continue to hamper effective IDP response in Guinea. The government body with primary responsibility for coordinating humanitarian assistance, including for IDPs, is the *Service National pour l'Action Humanitaire* (SENAH). Although SENAH is present in all four regions of Guinea, it is limited in both capacity and resources. Other than the immediate emergency response to the 2000-2001 attacks in Guinea's border areas, there has been scant assistance for IDPs, partly due to the lack of data on their numbers and needs. There has to date been no comprehensive vulnerability assessment of the relief and recovery needs of IDPs, returnees and host communities.

Moreover, Guinea hosted nearly one million refugees for almost ten years, with some 60,000 refugees from Liberia and Côte d'Ivoire remaining in camps in 2005. The lion's share of humanitarian assistance has been targeted at refugee populations. The 2005 Consolidated Inter-Agency Appeal (CAP) for Guinea requested \$39 million to provide assistance to conflict-affected populations, including IDPs, in and around the Forest Region, Haute Guinea and other areas. While 51 per cent of this amount was eventually funded, the majority was for UNHCR programmes.

The lack of a proper framework for tackling the protection and assistance needs of IDPs in Guinea is a fundamental issue. In most cases IDPs benefit only incidentally from relief and rehabilitation assistance provided to vulnerable groups in general. This includes improvement of access to health services, water, education, agriculture, food security and income generating programmes in the Forest Region and Haute Guinea – often implemented by UN agencies and NGOs using funds from their bilateral country programmes rather than through the CAP. Yet social indicators among communities hosting IDPs are comparatively lower than among refugees living in camps, and are continuing to slide ever lower.

Key recommendations to the government:

- Develop a national humanitarian action plan prioritising the needs of IDPs, returnees and host communities
- Develop and implement a strategy for IDP return or resettlement that is line with the UN Guiding Principles
- Improve and maintain basic infrastructure and social services in areas hosting IDPs
- Support peace and reconciliation efforts in areas hosting IDPs, returnees and ex-combatants